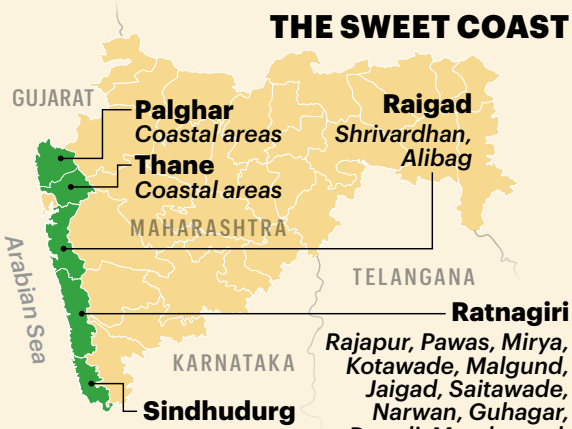
80 per cent PROJECTED DROP FROM THE AVERAGE ANNUAL OUTPUT OF 250,000 TONNES IN THE REGION

THE SWEET COAST



WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE TO SAVE ALPHONSO

- Curb excessive agrochemical use
- Check market competition among growers
- Build climate-resilient cultivation
- Conserve and boost pollinators and pollinisers
- Strengthen pest and disease control
- Develop improved graft mechanism
- Provide relief for growers
- Enforce GI tag, ensure traceability

lower prices. Arrivals are expected to pick up for less than a month after the fourth week of April, but growers fear this brief window will allow middlemen to squeeze prices, given the fruit's perishable nature.

Alphonsos grown in the Konkan's Ratnagiri, Sindhudurg, Palghar, Thane and Raigad have a Geographical Indication (GI) tag, which certifies their origin and protects their unique characteristics. Stakeholders complain that despite this, cheaper mangoes grown in states like Karnataka, Kerala, Gujarat and Tamil Nadu are sold to unsuspecting consumers as the original Hapus. The shortage of the Alphonso is expected to boost this 'counterfeiting'.

THE DOMINO EFFECT

The crop failure is expected to have a cascading effect on the local economy and beyond. In Ratnagiri's Pawas, Amar Desai, CEO of Desai Products, points to a room in his facility storing around 40 crates of mangoes. "Normally, it would have been full with around 300 crates," he says. Apart from the whole fruit, the company also sells mango products under the Desai Bandhu Ambewale Amar brand. He says poor availability is likely to push canning-grade mango prices by Rs 30-40 per kg this year. Mangoes that cannot be sold as

> **"WE HAVE URGED CHIEF MINISTER DEVENDRA FADNAVIS TO INCREASE THE COMPENSATION FOR ALPHONSO GROWERS"**
>
> 
>
> **NITESH RANE,** *Minister for Ports and Fisheries, and guardian minister for Sindhudurg, Maharashtra*

table fruit are usually sent for canning. Ratnagiri has over 100 canning units, on which an estimated 25,000 people depend.

Farmer Makarand Kane, who runs a canning unit at Reel in Ratnagiri, says he now has a staff of 45, down from 60, and plans to trim it further. Transporter Kaustubh Suhas Gogate from Jamsande, who picks up consignments from farmers, says margins are shrinking due to lower loads even as overheads like fuel and manpower costs continue to pinch. Similarly, pesticide and fertiliser vendors fear defaults, as many farmers buy inputs on credit. The ripple effects run even deeper. Vidyadhar Thakur, who makes *jhelas* or mango pluckers, has been able to sell just 200 this season, as against the average of 1,500. Nare, who owns a corrugated box manufacturing unit and purchased paper in large quantities, says he has material for around 250,000 boxes lying idle. The ripening chamber for which he charges Rs 80-100 per crate lies vacant, too.

PROMISES AMID PANIC

For decades, the Konkan and nearby areas were known as a 'money-order economy', with blue-collar workers from Mumbai sending remittances home for sustenance. That began to change in the 1990s, with the rise of Alphonso cultivation, which found markets in India and abroad. This, along with the growth of fisheries, tourism and cashew cultivation, transformed the region's economy. The Konkan and its mango orchards are now a magnet for migrants from states such as Uttar Pradesh and Jharkhand, and even Nepal, who work as labourers and watchmen in orchards. However, even as the region draws in migrant workers, many local youngsters are moving out. Farmers say the unpredictability of the business, the lack of dignity for physical labour and the pull of urban life have pushed them towards Mumbai and other cities—a trend the current crisis may hasten.

Minister Rane has a solution. Stating that climate change has affected all three mango flowering cycles, he says the government is tying up with the Agricultural Development Trust, Baramati, to incorporate Artificial Intelligence in mango cultivation. "This will help tackle the impact of climate change by ensuring weather forecasts, information on the crop, and on pesticide use." Amale says they will also promote the cultivation of black pepper—a climate-resilient crop—among mango farmers, and launch an awareness campaign urging cultivators to opt for agricultural insurance as a buffer against losses.

Despite these plans and promises, there is panic on the ground. In Kunkeshwar, farmer Eknath Teli says how there is a lot riding on the Konkan's Hapus. "If the king is dethroned, then what will happen to us?" he asks. ■